

TEST 4, WRITING TASK 2

This model has been prepared by an examiner as an example of a very good answer.

Due to improvements in healthcare, housing and sanitation, more people are reaching old age. Some feel that this causes unwanted pressure on society. Others say that this is a fallacy and that older people benefit their communities.

I can understand why some people are concerned. Many feel that older people are more accident-prone and less physically and mentally capable than younger people. The idea that older people are always sick and reliant on health services is also common. There may be a measure of truth to these claims, but I don't think it is fair to assume that older people are always dependent on others or contribute less to the workforce.

In many countries, the ageing population is a source of expertise that can be very useful to society. They add stability to the workforce bringing experience that younger people do not have. It is easy to overlook the substantial contributions older people make by doing unpaid work. In countries like the United States and China, millions of children are cared for by their grandparents. Mothers and fathers can then continue working while older ones take care of the children conveying cultural values to them in the process.

In view of the above, I feel that the advantages of an ageing population undoubtedly exceed any disadvantages. The prevalence of older people in society should not be viewed as a problem but rather as a solution to some of the problems that exist today.

Here are comments from another examiner:

The advantages and disadvantages of having an ageing population are clearly presented, and in the conclusion, the position is clearly stated. The candidate refers to the health challenges that old people face as the main disadvantage. In terms of advantages, the candidate points to the stability, experience and unpaid work of older people, especially in caring for grandchildren, which allows parents to work and instils cultural values.

Ideas are arranged logically and each paragraph has a clear central topic. The range of cohesive devices could be more varied, although there are some effective examples [*but* | *They* | *while*].

Vocabulary contains some degree of flexibility and precision [*unwanted pressure* | *accident-prone* | *measure of truth* | *source of expertise*].

Grammatical range is also good and demonstrates a wide range of structures. It is well controlled with few errors, but there are several shorter and simpler sentences. The response could be improved grammatically by increasing the number of complex or multi-clause sentences.

The word count is slightly below the minimum of 250 words and should be extended. For example, ideas could be added on the 'problems [this creates] for governments' as the candidate mentions only a concern about health.